Platform incident session

Briefing for the candidate. The company, the platform, the people and the incident are fictional.

The company

A healthcare software company. Its platform serves enterprise health plans, whose reviewers work cases in the payer app, and the provider offices and partner systems that send those cases in. Clients audit its security every year (SOC 2 reports and HIPAA obligations). Engineering is 12 people; AI coding agents author most changes, and how those changes are reviewed is not yet standardised. Alarms post to a shared channel, many of them noise, and there is no paging rotation.

A recent incident

In June, a routine production deploy ran a migration that built an index on a busy table. Requests queued behind it and the review queue was degraded for about half an hour, until an engineer stepped in. The team made changes afterwards.

Your role

It is 16:30 UTC on 20 October 2026. You take over as incident lead from the on-call engineer. Nothing is resolved. The packet (*README.md*, *architecture.md*, dashboards, alarm history, the incident channel and the status page) is what you know when you start.

The session, 75 minutes

Part	Minutes	What happens
Brief	5	What you know, what you believe, what you need.
Customer call	5	Harborview's IT director wants to know what is being done and how serious it is.
Diagnosis	25	You lead. Post what you need in the call chat for Tomas.
Stabilise	15	What you do, in what order, and how you know each step worked. We tell you what happens.
Team sync	5	We agree together on what happened and on the next steps.
Write-up	15	A short exercise based on the incident; we explain it then.
Customer call	5	A second, short call with Harborview's IT director, following from the write-up.

What arrives when

- **Now:** this packet, in a GitHub repository we sent you the link to. Prepare however you like, including with AI tools. Until the session the repository holds the packet and a placeholder for the code; check your editor and AI tool can open it.
- **When the session starts:** we replace the placeholder with the real source code and tell you when to update your copy.
- **In the session:** you cannot push. Post what you want done in the call chat for Tomas, our platform engineer: logs, state, a command, a change. Results arrive in the repository (run *git pull*). Logs come one service and 15 minutes at a time.
- **Right after the session:** we delete the repository.
- **At any time:** posts to the customer status page. Give us the component, the status and the exact text, and we publish it as written.

What we look at

How you use evidence and separate what you know from what you think; whether you find the cause and what confirms it; the order and safety of what you do; how you communicate inside the team and with the customer; how you direct and check your AI tools. We do not expect working code or knowledge of our real systems.

Please keep this material private. It is fictional, but it is ours.